

experts as there were a decade ago, which is what Mr. Leffert was getting at. It's very easy to call yourself a financial planner. In fact, any out-of-work diesel mechanic or laid-off saxophone player can become one by putting up a shingle to that effect. The 10,000 stockbrokers at Merrill Lynch have renamed themselves financial consultants and have received new business cards, while the stockbrokers at Shearson Lehman refer to themselves as financial consultants as well.

A dilemma for the client, Mr. Leffert recognized, is finding a planner who knows what he's about. The hard part is that there's no simple measure of success and no agreement as to what good planning really entails. In other fields where it's difficult to distinguish success from failure—such as in government bureaucracy, academia, or European aristocracy—titles and certifications abound. This is also true in financial planning.

Mr. Leffert said there are certified financial planners and registered financial planners, plus several gradations of consultants. He named various organizations to which planners belong—including the International Association for Financial Planning (IAFP)—and the various tests that planners may take, including the CFP given by the College of Financial Planning and the ChFC, which is an offshoot of something called the CLU.

Mr. Leffert guessed that of all the planners only a thousand or so had an adequate foundation and less than half that number were "extremely well qualified." Though he admitted there's no agreement on this, he suggested that to be absolutely safe the client should look for a firm that covers as many bases as possible, and whose employees are connected to the CFP, have passed their ChFC, and are registered with the IAFP as well. Happily, this was the case with his own firm, M. H. Senzel. Personally, Mr. Leffert was both a certified and a registered financial planner, CFP and RFP.

(Later, I was disturbed to read in the newspapers that a dog named Boris Bo Regaard of Tampa, Florida, was accepted into the IAFP, one of the important associations that Mr. Leffert had mentioned. I phoned their headquarters in Atlanta and spoke to Dick Williams in public relations. He assured me that the application for the dog was filled out with false information and its